

described the wounds as being so bad the operations that were carried out had no name: they were simply “horridzomas” or “horriblectomies.” Female nurses also dealt with stresses that were unique to their gender. According to one study, 63 percent of them experienced sexual harassment, ranging from “small pranks” to rape.

## **Nurse casualties**

Lieutenant Sharon Lane was the only nurse killed as a direct result of enemy action. The blast from an artillery round struck her while she was working at the 312th Evacuation Hospital in Chu Lai on June 8, 1969. In addition, several nurses died in helicopter crashes, including Second Lieutenant Carol Drazba and Second Lieutenant Elizabeth Ann Jones, both assigned to the Third Field Hospital in Saigon, and Captain Mary Therese Klinker, a flight nurse who died assisting the evacuation of orphans during Operation Babylift in 1975.

## **Expert care**

As a result of their experiences, nurses in Vietnam became more specialized than they would have been in civilian practice. Especially in the areas of trauma, critical care, and anesthesia, military nurses often developed expertise that gave them increasing autonomy. In mass casualty situations, nurses also took on triage of the wounded—the responsibility for determining who received care first and who was beyond medical help. The important role of nurses was recognized. In 1970, Colonel Anna Mae Hays, the chief of the Army Nurse Corps who had built the nursing staff in Vietnam, became the first woman in the US military ever to be promoted to the rank of brigadier general.